# Karl Ernst von Baer — *Reden und kleinere Aufsätze* (1864–1876)

*The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.*

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

## Dedication

To Karl Ernst von Baer, remembered first as a founder of embryology, and honoured here as a public thinker. Across the addresses and essays gathered between 1864 and 1876, the year of his death, he set out a universal law of development, asked which conception of living nature is the right one, wrote on purposiveness in organic bodies, and answered Darwin in a systematic critique of 245 pages. English readers have largely had to take that thinking at second hand, in German citations. This edition is dedicated to bringing his own statement, in his own order, to readers who have waited too long to hear him directly.

## The author's own terms

Von Baer writes of Zielstrebigkeit in organic bodies: purposiveness, the striving toward an aim in living bodies.

## The story

Karl Ernst von Baer is remembered in this collection first as a founder of embryology, the study of development before birth. This dossier concerns a different side of him: von Baer the public thinker, setting out in addresses and shorter essays what he believed nature's order to be, and answering, at great

length, the theory of Charles Darwin.

The work is *Reden und kleinere Aufsätze*, addresses and smaller essays, published in three volumes at St. Petersburg between 1864 and 1876. Part 1 is the *Reden*, the addresses. Part 2 is *Studien aus dem Gebiete der Naturwissenschaften*, studies from the field of the natural sciences. Part 3 is *Historische Fragen mit Hülfe der Naturwissenschaften*, historical questions treated with the help of the natural sciences.

Together they let a reader follow an eminent naturalist thinking in public over many years: first about a general law of development, then about how living nature should rightly be understood, then about purpose in living bodies, and finally about Darwin. English readers, however, have largely had to take that thinking at second hand, in German citations with bracketed translations of the titles. No English edition of the *Reden/Aufsätze* was found after research, as the record below makes plain.

This dossier is a companion to the separate dossier on von Baer's *Entwickelungsgeschichte*, his work on developmental history.

## The work and what survives

The key contents are identified with page anchors, so that a future edition can be planned from the record rather than from guesswork.

In Part 1, at pages 35–74, stands "Das allgemeine Gesetz der Natur in aller Entwickelung," the 1834 address on the most universal law of nature in all development. Also in volume 1, at pages 237–284, is "Welche Auffassung der lebenden Natur ist die richtige?…," which asks which conception of living nature is the right one.

In volume 2, at pages 171–234, is "Über Zielstrebigkeit in den organischen Körpern insbesondere," on purposiveness — the striving toward an aim — in organic bodies in particular. Then, at pages 235–480 of the same volume, comes "Über Darwins Lehre," on Darwin's teaching. It is a 245-page systematic critique, described in *Darwin in Russian Thought* as one of the first systematic and comprehensive critiques of Darwin. That description is carried here as the dossier records it: attributed to that book, and bounded by it.

The work was published between 1864 and 1876, and von Baer died in 1876, so

it is in the public domain.

A later check pinned down part of the text. Part 1 is pinned and verified: Internet Archive `bub_gb_FeYEAAAAYAAJ` (Google Books id FeYEAAAAYAAJ; IA ark:/13960/t0jt2hk32; 505 pp.), opened in this research. The item's contents line lists Th. 1–3, but the holding copy is "Th. 1 only." Part 1 covers two of the four pieces in the selected *Addresses* plan set out below: the 1834 "most universal law" address and "Welche Auffassung der lebenden Natur ist die richtige?…"

Parts 2 and 3 were not surfaced on IA in this pass. Part 2, *Studien aus dem Gebiete der Naturwissenschaften*, which contains the Zielstrebigkeit essays and "Über Darwins Lehre," and Part 3, *Historische Fragen*, remain to be obtained directly from HathiTrust, MDZ or Google Books before an edition is prepared. The fuller hardening record is in `HARDENING-CHECKS-SECOND-PASS.md` §3c. Earlier, no stable IA identifier for the *Reden* had been surfaced by the reviewer's searches, although auction records confirm the St. Petersburg set circulates.

## Its English fortunes

No English edition of the *Reden/Aufsätze* found after research. English scholars cite it in German, with bracketed title translations.

Two things that are in English must be kept apart from this work, because they are not this work. One is von Baer's *Autobiography*, edited by Oppenheimer and translated by Schneider in 1986, which is in copyright. The other is the 1827 ovum letter *De ovi mammalium*, translated by O'Malley in *Isis* 47, in 1956. Neither of those makes the *Reden* available in English.

## What completing it would take

The record advises plainly: do not attempt all three volumes at once.

A selected *Addresses* volume, bringing together the 1834 law address, "Welche Auffassung…," and the two Zielstrebigkeit essays, is coherent and completable. It would give English readers von Baer's own statement of his view of living nature, in his own order.

"Über Darwins Lehre" alone is a standalone second volume. At 245 pages, and with the standing described above, it is large enough and distinct enough to stand by itself, as a considered answer to Darwin by one of the leading naturalists

of the preceding generation.

## Sources

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- https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s13752-014-0180-0 (1834 address anchor)
- https://publishing.cdlib.org/ucpressebooks/view?docId=ft5290063h ("Über Darwins Lehre" as systematic critique)
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